

You've been seeing Desktop PCs move from the privacy of the bedroom to the living room... and all the family loves it! So which one will grace your centre-table?

Michael Browne

Pease of mind. The phrase probably has you thinking warm summer beaches, and coconut trees, gently swaying in the breeze—all taken in with cool lemonade in hand. But what about when you're not holidaying—hard at work at your Desktop, when suddenly, something goes wrong? Many PC vendors are elusive when it comes to offering after-sales support, and the wide, genuine smile fades the moment you hand over the cheque...

When it comes to purchasing a Desktop PC, a large chunk of users prefer to forego the small financial savings associated with assembling a PC, and buy a branded PC. In fact, the branded and assembled markets



centrePieCe!



have an equal fan following. We aren't here to propagate either vendors or brands—and the choice of assembled or branded largely depends on the kind of person you are, your exact needs, and how much you're willing to learn.

If you're new to the world of computers, you have a couple of options before making a purchase decision. This assumes you're interested enough in making an

informed decision. If you aren't interested in getting into computer components and want a ready-made solution, then a branded Desktop is for you. Or you could learn a bit about individual components like motherboards, processors, memory, hard drives, and others, and use that knowledge to assemble a PC where you get to play creator and hand-pick components.

The most important factor associated with branded PCs isn't their "hassle free" acquisition, but the fact that brands mean warranties—and warranties mean no hassles after

purchasing. All major brands now offer at least a year's warranty on their Desktop PCs; some of them offer support for three years. On-site support is another catch-phrase, and basically means you will have a support engineer dropping over the next time that box gives you trouble!

We did a comprehensive survey of the market and came up with the 17 contestants you'll see pitched side by side. Dig in and get comfortable—this promises to be quite the contest!

BASIC BOXES Desktops Between Rs 20,000 And Rs 30,000

If it sounds too good to be true, it *could* be true...! PC prices have well and truly crashed to new depths. While we aren't seeing very cheap (read Rs 10,000 and below) computers, we're getting better technology for our buck—for the last couple of years. Today a Core 2 Duo costs less than what an Athlon 64 cost a couple of years ago, which was in turn cheaper than the Pentium 4s of the early 21st century. And so, for the first time, this humble value category sees fast dual-core processors.

Features What...at that price?

Good PCs don't come cheap. We've been long-term believers of functionality over funkiness; however, the phrase "bang for the buck" comes to mind. The Intex PCs sport identical cabinets—only their mental acumen differ. The decent-looking (if plain) cabinet bespeaks functionality, and we liked the simple build. With easily accessible USB ports and well-built HIDs (human



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